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rising construction costs that have impacted the margins for affordable housing development. To address this, the adoption of a manufacturing approach to real estate—focussing on standardisation, scale, and technological innovation—would prove pivotal.

Perception remains another hurdle, as affordable housing is often stigmatised as low-quality or a last resort for those unable to afford better options. This stigma has made developers reluctant to enter this space, despite clear demand visibility.

The Government of India's initiatives under the vision of 'Housing for

All' have significantly supported the development of affordable housing in the country. The Credit Linked Subsidy Scheme under the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana illustrates this success, disbursing ₹58,900 crore in subsidies to 2.5 million beneficiaries, democratising homeownership for lower- and middle-income groups.

The government's recent announcement to support the construction of 30 million affordable houses, including 10 million homes in urban areas, further underscores this opportunity. This initiative itself represents a \$500-billion business

opportunity, necessitating at least \$100 billion in investment from both the public and private sectors.

However, if 'Housing for All' is to truly succeed in letter and spirit, it must be a private sector-led initiative. The success story of one of India's Top 10 developers, which began its journey as an affordable and mid-income housing developer in a single micro-market just eight years ago, clearly debunks the myth that affordable housing is unattractive for the private sector.

Housing stands as the quintessential "merit good" in economic parlance, much like a modern-day *Kamadhenu* (the Indian bovine goddess), nurturing security and financial inclusion for homeowners while serving as a fountainhead of India's economic prosperity.

India's affordable housing sector is on the cusp of a \$500-billion opportunity that checks all the right boxes—scale, social impact, business potential, and resilience to market cycle disruptions. The opportunity is real and tangible, driven by a young and growing population. The supply side is ripe for a paradigm shift, with new construction technologies and approaches waiting to be adopted and scaled.

With the right mix of vision, policy support, and investment, this sector could unlock a multi-decadal growth story that addresses a critical human need while offering enormous business potential.

Much like savouring *desi* Indian *chaat* at a Michelin-starred restaurant, affordable housing offers the best of both worlds: a sustainable, scalable business opportunity that provides profits with purpose across market cycles.

All it requires now is unleashing the quintessential Indian entrepreneurial zeal. **BT**

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